

NANDAN DAVE

banking, excess power generated by an RE generator is deposited in the grid and is supplied back to the user when the generation is low. The grid typically charges the depositor for this. For commercial and industrial power generators, says Shah, the previous solar policy framework meant consumers couldn't use RE except in daytime hours, leaving RE producers with little incentive to generate more power. With the billing cycle basis now, that limitation too has been deftly resolved.

Finally, the new policy engages with consumers to drive a shift to clean energy. Under the new rules, consumers can buy 100 per cent of their power through RE sources, for which discoms will fix separate tariffs. The policy also allows the development of small-scale wind energy projects on rooftops or within residential premises with net or gross metering arrangements with discoms (under net metering, power exports to the grid are adjusted as credits against imports, lowering the power bill, while in gross metering, the entire solar power generated is exported to the grid and the user is compensated at a fixed rate). Also, residential solar power users don't need to pay banking charges now.

There are teething troubles, too, though, which the Gujarat government needs to look into for the new rules to shape up well in action. Lack of clarity on how rates will be decided under the new rules is one. Also, the government's aim to replicate its success with rooftop solar projects with similar wind projects is ambitious, given the limited technology. "Wind power projects requirements and costs are far more elaborate," says Shah.

Nonetheless, the state hopes the policy will go a long way in utilising the natural advantages Gujarat has. Says Dr Sweta Purohit, programme director (climate change) at the Centre for Environment Education, "The availability of resources for the RE sector in Gujarat are at par with several other states, but one of the reasons that this western coastal state is doing better is its strategic location. On the one hand, there is a good solar and wind potential and on the other, there are ports and harbours that help investors economise on the transportation cost. Plus, a conducive ecosystem in terms of entrepreneurship and investor-friendly governance also exists here." In that sense, the new policy powers up a long-needed transition. ■

KARNATAKA

Averting A Power Disaster

By Ajay Sukumaran

Drought-hit Karnataka is now reeling under a double whammy, with a surge in energy demand owing to a weak monsoon adding to the misery already wrought by the latter. Over the past few weeks, the state has declared a drought in 216 of its 236 talukas and the extent of farm losses is estimated to run into Rs 30,000 crore. Alongside, the low inflow into hydel reservoirs, which Karnataka relies on for a bulk of its electricity generation, has resulted in an acute power problem. This is because drought-hit farmers are depending solely on electric pump sets this season to save standing crops.

"One reason is there is no rain. All of a sudden, (power) demand has gone up," says Karnataka energy minister K.J. George, pointing out that demand reached a peak of 16,000 MW in August-September, much more than was seen last year. "Normally, we shut down our thermal plants in monsoon as there is no need of thermal power. But this time, we have started them." Karnataka has a total installed capacity (as of November 2022) of 31,634.6 MW; overall, there's a shortfall of 1,500-2,000 MW despite an increase in generation compared to the previous year.

There's already a political wrangle brewing. While the BJP threatened to lock up the electricity supply company offices if farmers were denied seven hours of uninterrupted power, H.D. Kumaraswamy of the Janata Dal (Secular) has demanded a white paper on the power sector. "The previous BJP govern-

16,950 MW
Peak demand in Karnataka on August 25 (as against 11,268 MW on August 25, 2022)

40-50 million units (MU)
Daily power shortfall in Karnataka

₹1,102 cr.
Amount spent to procure 1,627 MU in April-October